# NovaTech Systems — Incident Management Runbook

NovaTech Systems • Internal Knowledge Base Document

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## Purpose and scope

Defines severity, incident roles, communication, mitigation, resolution, and postmortem practices, with a fictional NovaFlow incident example.

All names, systems, processes, dates, limits, and examples in this document are fictional and exist only for the NovaTech Systems RAG knowledge-base exercise.

## 1. Incident Definition

An incident is an unplanned event that materially affects availability, performance, security, correctness, or customer experience of a NovaTech service.

## 2. Severity Levels

| Severity | Definition | Typical response |
|---|---|---|
| SEV-1 | Major production outage affecting many customers | Immediate incident command, frequent communication, executive/customer escalation as applicable |
| SEV-2 | Significant degradation affecting a subset of customers | Rapid mitigation with coordinated engineering and customer communication |
| SEV-3 | Limited impact with a workaround available | Team-led response during business/operational hours as appropriate |
| SEV-4 | Minor issue with negligible customer impact | Normal prioritization and tracking |

## 3. Incident Roles

- Incident Commander (IC): owns coordination, priorities, decisions, and overall incident flow.
- Technical Lead: directs technical investigation and mitigation.
- Communications Lead: prepares internal and customer-facing updates when required.
- Subject Matter Experts: investigate specific services or dependencies.
- Scribe: records timeline, decisions, hypotheses, and actions.

## 4. Standard Lifecycle

1. Detect and declare the incident.
2. Assign an Incident Commander and establish a communication channel.
3. Assess severity and customer/business impact.
4. Stabilize the system; mitigation takes priority over perfect root-cause understanding.
5. Investigate using logs, metrics, traces, recent changes, and dependency status.
6. Communicate material updates at an appropriate cadence.
7. Verify recovery with smoke tests and monitoring.
8. Close the incident after stability is established and assign post-incident actions.

## 5. Sample Fictional Incident — NovaFlow

Incident ID: NF-INC-2026-041. Date: 2026-08-19. Severity: SEV-2. Impact: A subset of enterprise NovaFlow customers experienced delayed workflow executions for approximately 28 minutes.

| Time (IST) | Event |
|---|---|
| 11:07 | Monitoring detected elevated workflow-queue latency. |
| 11:11 | SRE confirmed customer-visible execution delays and declared SEV-2. |
| 11:16 | Technical investigation identified elevated latency in a downstream queue-processing dependency. |
| 11:23 | Processing capacity was increased and a safe mitigation was applied. |
| 11:31 | Queue latency returned to normal; smoke tests passed. |
| 11:35 | Incident moved to monitoring and customer communication was updated. |

### Lessons and follow-up

- Add an earlier alert for sustained queue wait-time growth.
- Review queue capacity thresholds for peak enterprise workloads.
- Document the dependency failure mode in the NovaFlow operational runbook.
- Validate that retry behavior remains safe and does not amplify downstream load.

## 6. Postmortem Requirements

SEV-1 and material SEV-2 incidents should receive a postmortem appropriate to impact. A postmortem should distinguish contributing factors from root cause, document customer impact, capture the timeline, and assign actionable follow-up owners.

## 7. Related Documents

- NT-ENG-001 — Engineering Handbook
- NT-SEC-001 — Security Policy
- NT-PROD-001 — NovaFlow Documentation
- NT-IT-001 — IT Support Guide